



LCD Monitors (17-inch)

Acer AL1714sm

Specs: 350:1 Contrast ratio, 370cd/m2 Luminance, 14 ms Response Time, Inbuilt Speakers

Our Verdict: The combination of features and performance was just about right, but the Acer AL1714sm is also unbeatably priced. Even the response time, among other features, matches the necessary standard. The viewing angle of the screen, and the colour reproduction, are remarkable. The screen also showed low ghosting effect while playing movies—thanks to the 14 ms response time. Crisp colour repro-

duction at high resolutions is comparable to that seen on high-end LCD screens.

The unit itself is compact with an oval base—it is approximately two inches thick. Unfortunately, the inbuilt speakers are not good enough for music. We must emphasize that the Acer AL1714sm offers amazing value for money!



Runner-Up: CMV CT-712A

MOTHERBOARDS

With Onboard Graphics For AMD Processors (Low-End)

MSI RS480M2-IL

Specs: Socket 939, PCI-Express, Onboard ATi Radeon XPress 200 Graphics, 10/100 LAN, FireWire, SATA With RAID, Four USB 2.0 Ports

Our Verdict: The MSI RS480M2-IL is based on the PCIe architecture and has an x16 slot for PCIe graphics cards, but the onboard graphics is decent enough for moderate gaming. It supports up to 4 GB of 400 MHz DDR memory in dual-channel mode.

All our tests without exception saw the RS480M2-IL posting high scores. It scored well in our gaming tests as well, on account of the onboard DirectX 9 graphics. This motherboard is dual-core ready, and can accommodate the X2.

Though it is priced considerably higher than other motherboards in its category, its excellent features and performance fetch the MSI RS480M2-IL our Zero1 Award.



Runner-Up: TUL A480A7-VF

Without Onboard Graphics For AMD Processors (Low-End)

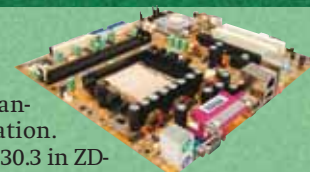
Winfast NF4K8MC

Specs: Socket 939, Supports AMD Athlon64 X2, PCI-Express, 8-channel Onboard Audio, Gigabit LAN, SATA With RAID, Four USB 2.0 Ports

Our Verdict: This motherboard is based on the nVidia nForce4 chipset usually found on high-end motherboards, which simply translates to high-end performance. This motherboard is AMD dual-core ready. It supports 3 GB of 400 MHz

DDR memory in dual-channel configuration.

A score of 30.3 in ZD-Bench Business Winstone 2004 means this is a motherboard that can handle office applications much better than other 'regular' motherboards can. Couple this with the fact that this is one of the lower-priced boards in this category, and we have a Zero1 Award winner!



Runner-Up: Winfast NF4K8AB

For Intel Processors (Low-End)

Mercury PI915GVM

Specs: Socket LGA775, PCI-Express architecture, Onboard Intel graphics, Four SATA ports, 10/100 LAN, Four USB 2.0 Ports.

Our Verdict: The Mercury PI915GVM is based on the Intel 915GV chipset, and has onboard graphics in addition to the PCIe graphics slot upgrade option. It supports up to 2 GB of both DDR as well as DDR2 memory at 400 MHz and 533 MHz respectively. The six-channel onboard audio is sufficient for home theatre use, gaming or music.

The scores this board posted in our stock benchmarks were all very good, and it is decent for moderate gaming requirements and effortless handling of day-to-day applications. It is a little expensive for an entry-level motherboard, but it showed good enough all-round performance to win our Zero1 Award.



Runner-Up: Gigabyte GA-8TR5 350MT